

MESU KENNINGS

A Courtly Register for the Language That Named Itself

me-na-me · saying within saying

What Is a Kenning?

In Old Norse and Old English poetry, a **kenning** is a productive metaphorical compound whose literal meaning is fully transparent but whose idiomatic meaning requires cultural convention to recover. *Whale-road* parses as "the road whales travel" but means *sea*. *Battle-sweat* parses as "the sweat produced in battle" but means *blood*. A listener who knows neither convention can still understand every morpheme — but they will miss the poem.

Mesu's design makes it **the most kenning-friendly language possible** while remaining the least euphemism-friendly. The compositional firewall guarantees every compound is parseable. The 48-root constraint forces poetic compression — there is no other way to talk about anything subtle. What this lexicon does is **fix conventions**: a community agreement that *certain* compounds carry *specific* non-literal meanings.

This is mesu's first courtly register. It is the seed of a literary tradition.

Reading the Entries

Each entry has the form:

┃ **kenning** (*literal parse*) — idiomatic reading *optional cultural note*

The literal parse uses Mesu's 48 roots and established fossils. The idiomatic reading is the *convention* — what a fluent speaker of the courtly register would hear.

I. LOVE, DESIRE, LONGING

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
wo-wi	big-feel	love (<i>general, established</i>)
pi-wi	hot-feel	desire, lust, embodied passion
nu-wi	new-feel	infatuation, the first weeks
pis-wip	fire-heart	lovesickness, being aflame for

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
lon-li	long-see	yearning, pining
wa-lip	wet-eye	moved to tears (by love or beauty)
pen-we-mi	part-of-me	beloved, the other half
le-wip	two-heart	soulmate, paired hearts
le-mep	two-mouth	kiss
wi-no-me	feel-not-say	unspoken love
lu we wip	know of heart	intimate knowing (<i>deep, possibly sexual</i>)
lon-pu	long-want	longing as a way of life

Field note: the field centres on the established root **wi** (feel). Native speakers should hear all twelve as a family. **pi-wi** / **pis-wip** are the burning ones, **lon-li** / **lon-pu** are the patient ones. A speaker who says only *mi i wo-wi a tu* in a courtly context is being deliberately ambiguous — they could mean love, friendship, or kinship, and the listener is expected to read context. Specificity comes from choosing a kenning.

II. DEATH, GRIEF, REMEMBRANCE

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
mo-la-nul	move-toward-dark	dying, the final journey
lon-nul	long-dark	death, eternal night
nul-mo	dark-walk	the death-walk (<i>also: depression</i>)
was-lip	water-eye	tears (<i>established</i>)
was we no-lin	water of death	mourning tears specifically
no-wi we wip	not-feel of heart	numbness, the grief that empties
pa-lum	before-person	ancestor, the honored dead
lin-su we pa	life-stuff of before	memory of the dead, what they left
mep we no-lin	mouth of death	last words
no-lin-su	not-life-stuff	corpse, the body emptied

Field note: grief in mesu courtly speech leans on **nul** (dark) and **no-lin** (death). The compound **nul-mo** carries a deliberate double meaning — it is *both* the journey of the dying and the inward darkness of the bereaved. This ambiguity is the kenning at work: a fluent speaker hears the resonance and doesn't choose.

III. WAR, CONFLICT, VIOLENCE

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
was we lin	water of life	blood
pi-was	hot-water	blood (visceral, of wounds)
was we wip	water of heart	heart's blood, lifeblood
ko-mep	hard-mouth	insult, harsh words
pi-me	hot-say	threat, anger spoken
pis-to	fire-thing	weapon
kep we no-lin	hand of death	killer, assassin
nam-mo	bad-move	attack, aggression
mo-la-nam	move-toward-bad	one's doom, going to destruction
mu-no-lin	many-death	massacre, slaughter
kep-pis	hand-fire	weapon-wielder, warrior

Field note: the blood kennings are pure Norse-style — three different liquids-of-life depending on register and emphasis. **was we lin** is the formal/poetic one; **pi-was** is the soldier's term; **was we wip** is the elegist's. A poem about a battlefield should probably use all three.

IV. KNOWLEDGE, WISDOM, MYSTERY

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
lon-lu	long-know	wisdom (<i>distinct from simple knowing</i>)
pa-lu	before-know	memory, ancestral knowledge
mu-lu	many-know	learning, scholarship

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
wo-lu	big-know	deep understanding, genius
lu-pen	know-part	a clue, a fragment
nul we lu	dark of know	mystery, hidden knowledge
lus	<i>fossil: lu-su</i>	information (<i>established technical</i>)
lu we lon	know of long	the long view, perspective
no-lu	not-know	ignorance
lu-no-me	know-not-say	secret, the held thing

Field note: this field interacts with your fossil registry. The **scholastic dialect** lives in this neighbourhood — *lus*, *sawen*, *nop*, *mesan* are all kennings in everything but name. The kenning register and the technical register are doing the same compression work for different audiences.

V. BEAUTY, ATTRACTION, RADIANCE

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
ma-li	good-see	beautiful (<i>established as adj.</i>)
pil-li	sun-see	radiant, dazzling beauty
lo-mep	bright-mouth	eloquent, the poet's voice
lo we lip	bright of eye	the spark in someone's eye
ma we mo	good of motion	grace, beauty in movement
nu-ma	new-good	freshness, the beauty of youth
lon-ma	long-good	beauty that endures, weathered grace
pil-sop	sun-head	bright-minded, brilliant (<i>of intellect</i>)

Field note: mesu lacks the lexical density to mark fine gradations of beauty (compare english *gorgeous* / *lovely* / *striking* / *handsome* / *radiant* / *cute*). The kenning system does this work compositionally: **pil-li** is dazzling, **nu-ma** is fresh, **lon-ma** is enduring, **lo we lip** is intimate. Each kenning is a *kind* of beauty.

VI. TRUTH, DECEPTION, HIDDEN MEANING

This is the field that matters most for your original question.

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
mesan	<i>fossil: me-san</i>	truth, bijection (<i>established technical</i>)
me we pa	say of before	promise, oath, given word
nam-me	bad-say	lie (<i>established</i>)
me-na-me	say-in-say	hidden meaning, the kenning itself
me-le	say-two	double-talk, deliberate ambiguity
nul-me	dark-say	coded speech, secret communication
ma-me we no-ma	good-say of bad	flattery, polite dishonesty
lu-no-me	know-not-say	secret, the held thing
me-no-wip	say-not-heart	hollow words, insincerity
me-win-wip	say-with-heart	sincere speech, words from the heart

Field note: me-na-me — *saying within saying* — is the kenning that names the courtly register itself. It is mesu's word for *kenning*. When you compose a poem in this register, what you are doing is *me-na-me*. The construction is recursive: it says of itself what it does.

VII. TIME, MORTALITY, NOSTALGIA

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
nu-lin	new-life	youth (<i>established as 'birth'</i>)
nun-lin	old-life	elder, the long-living
pa-lin	before-life	past life, what was
lon-mo we ne	long-walk of now	the slow present, melancholy duration
pa-su	before-stuff	the past as substance, what remains
ne-su	now-stuff	the present moment as a thing held
lon-pa	long-before	deep past, ancestral time

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
mo we ne	walk of now	aging, the daily passage

VIII. MIND, MADNESS, ALTERED STATES

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
lup	<i>fossil: lu-sop</i>	thought (<i>established</i>)
no-lu we sop	not-know of head	madness, mind-loss
pi-sop	hot-head	impulsive, passionate thinking
nul-sop	dark-head	depression, the dark mind
lo-sop	bright-head	inspiration, clarity
mu-wi we sop	many-feel of head	overwhelm, mental chaos
no-sop	not-head	thoughtlessness, foolishness
wo-sop	big-head	conceit, arrogance

Field note: every kenning here uses **sop** (head) as locus. This is the standard mesu cognitive metaphor — the head as container of mind-states. A speaker who hears any of these eight knows immediately that the topic is the inner life.

IX. POWER, RANK, AUTHORITY

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
wo-mep	big-mouth	chief, leader (<i>or: ironic — windbag</i>)
pan-li	all-see	seer, prophet, mystic
kep we pan	hand of all	ruler, the one who touches everything
wo-lum	big-person	great one, hero
mu-lum we so	many-people of above	nobility
so-lum	up-person	superior, one above

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
nus-lum	down-person	inferior, lowly (<i>use with care</i>)
me we pan	say of all	law-giver, judge

Field note: **wo-mep** is delicately context-dependent. Used in praise it means *leader*; used in mockery it means *blowhard*. This is mesu's first true contronym, and it lives entirely in the kenning register — no straightforward word can do this work.

X. NATURE AS METAPHOR

Classic kenning territory. Natural phenomena standing in for human conditions.

Kenning	Literal	Idiomatic
pil-mo	sun-walk	day's passage, the arc of a life
nul-pil	dark-sun	moon
wo-was	big-water	sea, ocean
lon-was	long-water	river
was we so	water of above	rain
pis we so	fire of above	lightning
mos we pi	air of hot	summer wind
mos we nip	air of cold	winter wind
lo we ne	bright of now	dawn
nul we ne	dark of now	dusk

Composition Rules for New Kennings

If a speaker wants to extend the register, three rules:

1. **Use only the 48 roots and established fossils.** No new morphemes. A kenning that requires a new word is no longer this register — it is just neologism.
2. **The literal parse must be transparent.** Every morpheme identifiable. If a listener cannot decompose your kenning, it is broken.

3. **The idiomatic meaning must require convention.** If the meaning falls out of the parts directly, you have made a description, not a kenning. *was-lip* (water-eye) for *tears* is on the boundary — the meaning is almost literal. *was we no-lin* (water of death) for *mourning tears* is clearly a kenning — you need the convention.
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Examples in Use

A short poem in mesu kennings (couplet form):

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mi i lon-li a tu na nul we ne.  
mi i wo-wi a tu pe wo-was.  
  
I [V] long-see [O] you in dark-of-now.  
I [V] big-feel [O] you before big-water.
```

Literal: *I look-long at you in the dark-of-now. I big-feel you before the big-water.*

Kenning-decoded: *I yearn for you at dusk. I love you facing the sea.*

A funeral fragment:

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si i mo-la-nul. mi-pan i ki a was we no-lin.  
si we mi-pan ne a lin-su we pa.  
  
She [V] move-toward-dark. We [V] have [O] water-of-death.  
She of us now [N] life-stuff-of-before.
```

She is dying. We have mourning tears. She, to us, is now memory of the dead.

A line of courtly indirection:

```
mi i me-na-me a tu.  
  
I [V] say-in-say [O] you.
```

I speak hidden meaning to you. The speaker is announcing — formally, ceremonially — that what follows is in the kenning register. This is the analogue of clearing your throat before a poem.

Measuring H_{hidden} for Kenning Mesu

Recall the four ambiguity vectors:

Vector	Base Mesu	Kenning Mesu
Lexical polysemy	~1.0 senses/root	~2.0 (literal + idiomatic)
Homophony	0 collisions	0 collisions (<i>unchanged</i>)
Syntactic parse	~1 tree/string	~1 tree/string (<i>unchanged</i>)
Pragmatic indirection	0	~50 conventionalized indirections

The kenning register **doubles polysemy** for the lexical items that participate, and **adds an entire pragmatic indirection layer** the base language lacks — without changing the phonotactics or grammar. This is the same trick high heian japanese and classical persian use: a literary register that overlays the everyday language with semantic depth, recoverable only by initiates.

A rough estimate: a kenning-fluent speaker can convey **~1 additional bit per kenning-bearing word** of "hidden" information that a non-initiated listener cannot decode. For a sentence with three kennings, that is three bits of in-group channel capacity — enough to distinguish eight distinct intended meanings of an apparently single utterance.

Mesu remains the coldest language in the survey — TL still ≈ 0.16 for the base register. But the kenning register sits above it like a courtly upper layer, accessible only to those who have learned the conventions. Just as latin's literary register sat above its vulgar one, and just as heian japanese poetry sat above the spoken tongue.

The language that named itself can now also name what it does not quite say.

me-na-me a mesu.
saying-within-saying is the language.